



www.smartystems.com

How to Use Claude for Research

A step-by-step guide for MSc and PhD students

WHAT'S INSIDE

- 5 stages of thesis research where Claude helps most
- 15 tested prompts you can copy and use today
- Real prompt examples with explanations of why they work
- What Claude cannot do and what to use instead
- A quick reference card at the end

WHO THIS IS FOR

MSc and PhD students who want to use AI tools smartly and ethically in their research.

Why This Guide Exists

Claude is powerful. But most researchers use it wrong.

Claude is one of the most capable AI tools available for academic research but only when you know how to prompt it correctly. Most students either ask it questions that are too vague and get useless answers, or they over-rely on it and produce work that lacks their own thinking.

This guide gives you exactly what to type at each stage of your thesis or dissertation starting from your research gap all the way to polishing your final draft. Every prompt has been tested and refined for academic research contexts.

Before you start: The Golden Rule

Claude is a thinking partner, not a ghostwriter. Use it to sharpen your ideas, challenge your arguments, and improve your writing not to replace your thinking. Always verify any facts, citations or statistics it produces independently.

WHAT CLAUDE IS GREAT FOR



Analysing long documents

Upload entire papers, reports or your own draft chapters and ask Claude to summarise, critique or extract key points.



Following complex prompts

Claude holds tone, word count, academic register and multiple instructions at once better than most AI tools.



Improving your writing

Paste your own paragraph and ask Claude to refine it while preserving your voice and argument.



Pressure-testing your ideas

Ask Claude to argue against your thesis statement. It will find the weakest points faster than you can.



Explaining difficult concepts

Paste a dense methodology section and ask Claude to explain it in plain language.

What Claude cannot do

Claude does not browse the web natively. It cannot retrieve live papers from Google Scholar or Scopus. Always verify citations since Claude can hallucinate references. For live search, use ChatGPT or Perplexity. Use Claude for analysis, writing and thinking. Use other tools for source discovery.

Stage 01: Defining Your Research Topic and Gap

Before you write a single word, Claude can help you think clearly.

The hardest part of any thesis is narrowing your topic and identifying a genuine research gap. Claude is exceptional at helping you stress-test your ideas and find angles you have not considered. Use these prompts at the very beginning of your research process.

PROMPT 1: REFINE YOUR TOPIC

I am writing a thesis on [your broad topic]. My field is [your discipline].
Help me narrow this into 3 more specific, researchable sub-topics.
For each, suggest a potential research question and explain what makes it original.

Why this works: Forces Claude to think about originality, not just summarise your topic.

PROMPT 2: FIND YOUR RESEARCH GAP

Here is my current understanding of the literature on [topic]:
[paste your summary or notes here]

Based on this, what are the most likely gaps or underexplored areas that a thesis could address? Give me 5 specific gap statements.

Why this works: You provide the context, Claude finds the angles you are missing.

PROMPT 3: CHALLENGE YOUR THESIS STATEMENT

My thesis statement is: "[paste your statement here]"

Argue against this statement. What are the 3 strongest objections a reviewer might raise? How could I strengthen my argument to address each one?

Why this works: Exposes weaknesses before your supervisor does.

Stage 02: Reading and Analysing Research Papers

Claude can read entire papers with you and extract exactly what you need.

Claude has a 200K token context window with the ability to read your entire thesis draft, multiple research papers, or a full literature review at once without losing track of earlier content. This is where Claude genuinely outperforms other AI tools for academic work.

PROMPT 4: SUMMARISE A PAPER FAST

[Paste the full text of the paper or abstract + results section]

Summarise this paper in exactly 3 sentences:

1. What they studied and why
2. What they found
3. How this is relevant to research on [your topic]

Why this works: The 3-sentence format forces precision and gives you a ready-made annotation.

PROMPT 5: EXTRACT METHODOLOGY DETAILS

[Paste the methodology section of the paper]

Extract the following in a table format:

- Research design
- Sample size and selection method
- Data collection method
- Analysis method
- Key limitations the authors mention

Why this works: Speeds up your methodology comparison across multiple papers.

PROMPT 6: COMPARE MULTIPLE PAPERS

I am going to paste summaries of 4 papers on [topic].

After reading all of them, compare them on:

1. Key findings and where they agree or disagree
2. Methodological differences
3. Gaps none of them address

[Paste Paper 1 summary] ... [Paste Paper 2 summary] ...

Why this works: Builds your comparative analysis automatically across sources.

Stage 03: Writing Your Literature Review

Stop summarising papers one by one. Start building a coherent argument.

The biggest mistake in literature reviews is writing a list of summaries instead of a synthesised argument. Claude can help you identify themes, build connections between sources, and write in a proper academic register. Always write the first draft yourself and use Claude to improve it.

PROMPT 7: IDENTIFY THEMES ACROSS YOUR SOURCES

I have reviewed the following papers on [topic]:
[List paper titles and one-line summaries]

Group these into 3 to 5 thematic clusters. For each cluster:

- Give it a label
- List which papers belong to it
- Write one paragraph synthesising the key argument of that cluster

Why this works: Transforms a list of papers into a structured review framework.

PROMPT 8: IMPROVE A PARAGRAPH YOU HAVE WRITTEN

Here is a paragraph from my literature review:
[Paste your paragraph]

Improve this paragraph while:

- Keeping my argument and all citations
- Using formal academic tone
- Making it flow better between sentences
- Keeping it under [X] words

Why this works: Claude improves your writing without replacing your ideas.

PROMPT 9: WRITE A TRANSITION SENTENCE

I am moving from a section about [Topic A] to a section about [Topic B] in my literature review. Write 3 transition sentence options that:

- Link the two topics logically
- Signal to the reader why this shift matters
- Maintain an academic tone

Why this works: Solves the hardest writing problem which is how sections connect.

Stage 04: Designing Your Methodology

Use Claude to justify your choices and anticipate examiner questions.

Your methodology chapter needs to do two things: explain what you did and justify why you did it that way. Claude is excellent at helping you articulate your rationale, find the right academic language, and prepare for the hard questions your examiner will ask.

PROMPT 10: JUSTIFY YOUR RESEARCH DESIGN

My research design is [qualitative/quantitative/mixed methods].
My data collection method is [interviews/surveys/secondary data/etc].
My research question is: [paste question]

Write a paragraph justifying why this design is appropriate for my research question, citing established methodological frameworks.

Why this works: Gets the academic justification language right immediately.

PROMPT 11: ANTICIPATE EXAMINER QUESTIONS

My methodology is: [brief description]
My sample size is: [number] selected by [method]

What are the 5 most likely critical questions an examiner would ask about this methodology? For each question, give me a suggested response I could use in my viva or written defence.

Why this works: Viva preparation built into your writing process.

PROMPT 12: WRITE YOUR LIMITATIONS SECTION

My research methodology is [description].
Known limitations include: [list what you already know]

Write a limitations section of approximately [X] words that:

- Honestly acknowledges these limitations
- Explains why the study is still valid despite them
- Uses hedging language appropriate for academic writing

Why this works: Transforms a weakness into a sign of academic maturity.

Stage 05: Editing and Finalising Your Thesis

Polish your writing without losing your voice.

The final stage is where Claude is most powerful. You have done the research and the thinking. now use Claude to sharpen your language, check your argument, and make sure every sentence earns its place. Never ask Claude to write whole sections from scratch at this stage. Use it surgically.

PROMPT 13: CHECK ARGUMENT CONSISTENCY

[Paste your introduction and conclusion]

Check whether my introduction and conclusion are consistent.
Does the conclusion answer the research question stated in the introduction?
Are there any claims in the conclusion not supported by the introduction?
Give specific line-by-line feedback.

Why this works: Catches the most common thesis structural error.

PROMPT 14: ACADEMIC LANGUAGE CHECK

[Paste a section of your thesis]

Review this section for academic writing quality. Flag any:

- Informal or conversational language
- Vague claims that need evidence
- Passive/active voice inconsistencies
- Repetition or redundant phrases

For each issue, suggest a specific correction.

Why this works: More precise than a grammar checker, more consistent than a human proofreader.

PROMPT 15: FINAL ABSTRACT CHECK

Here is my abstract:

[Paste abstract]

Check this abstract against the following criteria:

- Does it state the research problem clearly?
- Does it describe the methodology in one sentence?
- Does it state the key finding?
- Does it explain the contribution or significance?
- Is it within [X] words?

Rewrite any section that fails these criteria.

Why this works: Your abstract is the first and sometimes only thing reviewers read.

Quick Reference Card

Your go-to prompts at a glance

Stage	What to Ask Claude
Topic and Gap	Narrow my topic / Find research gaps / Challenge my thesis statement
Reading Papers	Summarise in 3 sentences / Extract methodology / Compare papers
Lit Review	Group into themes / Improve my paragraph / Write transitions
Methodology	Justify my design / Anticipate examiner questions / Write limitations
Editing	Check intro vs conclusion / Academic language audit / Abstract check

Remember: Claude + Your Thinking = Great Research

Claude is a tool. Your curiosity, your analysis and your original thinking are what make a great thesis. Use these prompts as a starting point and adapt them to your specific research context. The more context you give Claude, the better its output will be.

For more research tips and tools, visit www.smartystems.com